

Shoes of Faith

Go to the 900-year-old grave. Take your footwear in your hands. Hit it five times. Consider yourself blessed.

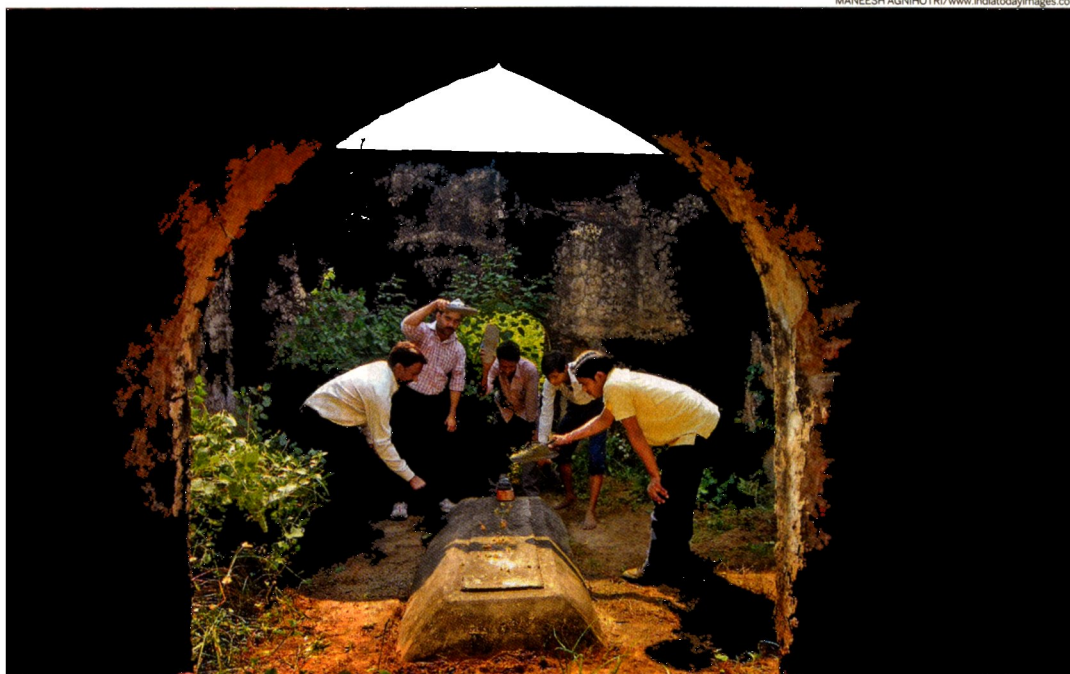
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THE FAITHFUL SEEK
A PLEASANT AND
SAFE JOURNEY

| By Farzand Ahmed |

Any time is worship time for travellers at the Maqbara of Chhugalchi (backbiter). Instead of burning incense sticks and offering flowers or coins, they beat the grave with shoes and pray for a safe journey. Unlike other mazaars, Chhugalchi ka Maqbara has no caretakers. Located on the outskirts of Etawah town on the Farukhabad-Kannauj highway, the grave inside the dilapidated tomb has a strange story. Just a fortnight back, a political activist from Etawah, Mohammad Mansoor, led his friends to the tomb to shower the grave with shoes and pray to help rid the Samajwadi Party of backbiters. Even highway travellers stop at the tomb to curse the *chhugalchi*.

Folklore has it that the original *chhugalchi* was a court-jester called Bhola Syed in the durbar of Raja Sumer Singh Chauhan in the period of Mohammad Ghauri's raids. He once went to see the Raja of Ater, Bhind, and in a bid to be rewarded handsomely, told the king that Chauhan was planning to annex his kingdom. On his return, he told Chauhan that the Raja of Ater was planning to attack him. This led to a war but the kings

learnt about Syed's mischief and ordered that he be beaten with shoes till he died. He was buried by the roadside and an order issued that passersby must hit his grave with shoes five times.

Well-known Hindi writer Medhavas Pathak, however, contends that the real *chhugalchi* was Gul Al-Farooz who was ordered to be buried half-dead with a chowkidar posted at his grave whose duty was to ask the travellers to hit the grave with shoes five times. "It is a symbol of hatred towards those who spread lies or speak spitefully or spread slander," says Pathak.

There are other mazaars too with weird tales. Lucknow, the city of nawabs, has a grave of Capstan Baba, a British army officer who died during the 1857 uprising. Both Hindus and Muslims offer Capstan cigarettes in memory of the soldier who used to smoke this cigarette. Similarly, Amroha has mazaars of revered Sufi saint Shah Wilyat Amrohi that has scorpions and of Sufi Khwaja Nasruddin guarded by donkeys. Strange are the ways of the faithful and stranger their ways of paying obeisance for seeking divine intervention. ■